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This Is Not a Hypertext: Scholarly Annotation and the Electronic Medium

BRUCE E. GRAVER

It is the purpose of this paper to raise questions about the hypertext model (or, more accurately, the hypertext synecdoche) for electronic scholarly editions. These questions arise from my experience as an editor for the Cornell Wordsworth, a project that, according to Jerome McGann, “has put a period to codex-based scholarly editions” (“Rationale”), and my experience as the coeditor of *Lyrical Ballads* for Cambridge University Press, which will be among the first of the new generations of electronic editions. I focus on the issue of annotation, partly because my Cornell Wordsworth volume is, for the series at least, heavily annotated and because the annotations in my *Lyrical Ballads* edition will seem, for an electronic edition, unusually spare. The reasons for this difference emerge in the course of my discussion, but here, at the outset, I would like to suggest that the ever-expanding, “radiant” model of the hypertext archive, eloquently envisioned by McGann and others (McGann, “Radiant Textuality”), is, in my view, something of a mistake.

But before I get too far ahead of myself, let me step back and talk about the problem of annotation in my Cornell volume, Wordsworth’s *Translations of Chaucer and Virgil*. The Cornell Wordsworth has usually avoided annotation of the historical or interpretive kind. Because of their extraordinary effort to present the full textual record of Wordsworth’s poems, from the earliest drafts down to the last lifetime (or first posthumous) publica-

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tion, its editors have maintained that annotations not concerned with textual matters add an undesirable layer of clutter to volumes that are already very large and very full. But for my translations volume, a significant exception was made. Why? Because, in the words of an anonymous NEH reviewer, “this promises to be one of the least interesting volumes in the series.” Wordsworth’s translations are virtually unknown even to Romantics, they do not have the cultural significance of the translations of Dryden or Pope, the bulk of them were left unpublished, and many are unfinished. So there is little apparent reason to devote editorial energy to them, except to complete and remain consistent with an ambitious editorial enterprise.

My challenge, then, was to find reasons why these poems are interesting and to make those reasons apparent. My means for doing so was annotation. A typical page of my edition of Wordsworth’s *Aeneid* has four bands of text: one containing the reading text of the translation and three in smaller type underneath. The top band in smaller type gives Coleridge’s unpublished notes to the translation, a wonderful find that, to my knowledge, only Robert Woof and Stephen Parrish had examined before I did. The middle band provides the critical apparatus of verbal variants, such as one would find in any variorum edition, and the bottom band contains extensive annotations about Wordsworth’s methods of translation—comparisons between the translation and the Latin, suggestions about ways in which his translation may have been influenced by prose paraphrases and scholarly commentaries, passages in his original poems that allude to the *Aeneid*, and, of course, obligatory attempts to explain Coleridge’s comments. In addition, after the reading text, a lengthy set of editorial notes records Wordsworth’s borrowings from four earlier translations of the *Aeneid*: the translations of John Ogilby (the 1650 edition that Wordsworth owned, which is now in the Wordsworth Library, Grasmere), John Dryden, Joseph Trapp, and Christopher Pitt. Now all of this means that in addition to tracing the full textual history of Wordsworth’s poems, I have attempted to illustrate Wordsworth’s methods when translating and assess (or present the evidence for assessing) his place in the history of English translation. As my reviewer for the Center for Scholarly Editions realized, the volume thus incorporates a monograph on Wordsworth as a translator, and in this respect it is unique in the Cornell Wordsworth series.

The volume also has the most complicated page layout of the entire Cornell Wordsworth series, a fact that caused me and the editorial board more than a few moments of anxiety. But I ultimately came to regard the complexity of the pages as a kind of rhetorical statement about the value and interest of my little-regarded texts. Moreover, the page layout, with its

various layers of annotation, enforces a special discipline on those who attempt to read the volume: readers are constantly led away from the text and back to it again; they are forced to keep track of different kinds of annotation, sometimes in different parts of the volume. In short, they cannot lightly skim. Annotation, in this respect, is a rhetorical means of impressing readers with the significance of the poetry, and it is also a means of rehabilitating the poetry, by forcing readers to scrutinize Wordsworth's efforts as a translator in unprecedented ways. If one chooses to read the edition at all, one must read slowly, painstakingly, and in that way impart value to the poetry that it has not previously been accorded.

Late in the preparation of this volume, I received a mandate from Cornell University Press, requiring me to deliver my work in camera-ready copy, typeset in PageMaker according to series specifications. When I had more or less gotten over the shock, I counted my pennies, called Aldus, Adobe, and Gateway 2000, and entered the computer world in a very big way very suddenly. Sometime in the fall of 1994, after the volume was typeset and I was checking cross-references, I noticed that there were seven windows open at once on my computer terminal, all of which showed pages that refer to the same passage of text but that appear at different places in the volume, some of them several hundred pages apart. I could switch from one window to another quite easily, put them side by side for close comparison, change the size of a window to focus my view: all this the computer environment allowed me to do. But to do the same thing in the printed book, I realized, would be difficult at best, if not impossible. Now the fall of 1994 was also about the time that Netscape released the first version of its World Wide Web browser, instantly making a word like *hypertext* part of the everyday vocabulary of educated people. I acquired a copy, started surfing, and was fascinated. Here, I thought, was a medium that would make the kind of edition I was preparing much easier to use. I jumped in feet first and in just a few weeks found a collaborator, Ronald Tetreault of Dalhousie University (we met by e-mail); in just a few months we were contacted by Kevin Taylor of Cambridge University Press about preparing an edition of *Lyrical Ballads*. It was breathtakingly fast.

Initially, our plan was to develop a McGann-inspired hypertext archive. In the project description submitted to Cambridge University Press, we proclaimed that our edition

will include all the print versions of the [*Lyrical Ballads*]*—*1798 (both the “Lewti” and “Nightingale” printings), 1800, 1802, and 1805*—*and, for the poems by Wordsworth, all of the versions of *Lyrical Ballads* works that the poet reprinted in the various collective editions of his poetry. We will

also include the printer's manuscripts of *Lyrical Ballads*, both in digital reproduction and transcription, and any other manuscript notebooks and letters that contain drafts and corrections of *Lyrical Ballads* material.

We would also bring together source material, authorial comments, unauthorized publications (including the American *Lyrical Ballads* and the chapbooks of individual poems), and even reviews of the collection: everything that had anything to do with *Lyrical Ballads* and the individual poems published in it. Virtual space, we thought, was virtually unlimited, and we could prepare an edition of *Lyrical Ballads* that combined traditional variorum, facsimile, bibliography, and illustrative commentary in ways unthinkable to those whose sense of editing was defined by the limits of the printed book. We set to work collecting this material, giddy with enthusiasm.

The enthusiasm has not subsided—much—but the giddiness has, as we have confronted the practical realities of delivering an actual product. The limitations of software, the awkwardness of SGML markup (not to mention learning how to do it), the difficulties and costs of digital reproductions of manuscripts, and the simple fact that *Lyrical Ballads* is a very well edited text forced us over and over again to rethink our project and change its scope. One of our biggest challenges was to differentiate ourselves from the Cornell edition of *Lyrical Ballads*, edited by James Butler and Karen Green and published in 1992. We saw pretty clearly that pursuing our original plan would mean merely repeating much of their work, and that was not acceptable. Anyone who has examined the draft manuscripts of Wordsworth's "Michael," for instance, and has looked at Karen Green's painstaking transcriptions of them in the Cornell volume knows that this is work that need not be done again. Anyone who has checked James Butler's collations of the collective life editions of Wordsworth's contributions to *Lyrical Ballads* (as I have done) will not see much use in yet another variorum collation. Coincidentally, the Butler-Green edition provided the solution to our dilemma. There, in describing their reading text of *Lyrical Ballads* (1800), the most bibliographically complex of all Wordsworth's publications, they write:

A reading text based on [the 1800 printer's manuscripts] emphasizes what Wordsworth actually wrote [. . .]; a text based on the printed volume, despite its flaws, highlights *Lyrical Ballads* as an influential historical artifact. Both goals, contradictory as they are, are valid: our aim, though, is to stress Wordsworth as author more than *Lyrical Ballads* as book. (127)

That is, Butler and Green were in pursuit of that elusive idea, authorial intent. In so doing, they neglect (and in one case were even forbidden to

report)¹ the characteristics of the printed books that people actually read. Those interested in the material form of *Lyrical Ballads* may find, buried in footnotes, manuscript descriptions, and appendixes, some of the information that they need. But reconstructing what the printed volumes consisted of in 1802 or 1805 or even in 1800 is very difficult, and in an age when bibliography and scholarly editing are no longer a standard part of graduate education, it is nearly impossible for many active scholars to do.

So we decided to present in our edition the history of the various artifacts, published in Wordsworth's and Coleridge's lifetimes, that called themselves *Lyrical Ballads*.² We have keyed our texts to specific copies of the collection; we will present digital images of the various states of the published pages, including the canceled "Christabel" leaf from the 1800 "Preface" and the "Michael" cancels and the "Michael" paste-in from *Lyrical Ballads* (1800); and we will present full texts of each of the five "Lewti" copies of *Lyrical Ballads* (1798), bearing the Bristol imprint, each of which survives in a bibliographically different state. Manuscript material will be largely avoided, except when revisions have been entered in printed copies by the authors or their amanuenses or when the material is clearly part of the printer's manuscripts of *Lyrical Ballads*. Our edition will also include unauthorized printings of the collection, if they called themselves *Lyrical Ballads*, and our chief witness of this kind will be the Wordsworth Library copy of the extremely rare 1802 Philadelphia printing, a copy presented by Professor Henry Reed of the University of Pennsylvania to Wordsworth himself in the late 1830s. There is no library that has all these books, and no traveling exhibition, even in the bicentenary year of 1998, will ever bring them together in one place. This is the kind of thing that the electronic environment can do, and do very well.

This edition will of course have many hypertextual features: the ability to move directly from the text to an image of the printed page or from the text to a critical apparatus, the ability to set different versions of poems side by side for purposes of comparison, and even (we are told) simultaneous scrolling of open text windows. But it would be a mistake, I believe, to regard it simply as a "hypertext," at least in the sense in which promoters and theorists of hypertext have intended the term. We are not interested in "nonlinear" modes of thought; rather, we are intent on providing scholars with evidence that will allow them to draw very "linear" conclusions about this collection of poems. We are not interested in creating a vast, complex web of documents, at the center of which is a *Lyrical Ballads* poem, but which is so rich in annotation that the poem is buried beneath the weight of its associated texts. Rather, we are interested in providing a limited set of

documents, annotated only with bibliographical descriptions, that will allow for careful, focused study of the history of the printed artifact, *Lyrical Ballads*, one of the most important collections of poetry ever published in our language.

But, even more, we realize the necessity of convincing skeptical, technophobic colleagues of the usefulness of the electronic medium. These are people, on the whole, for whom “nonlinear” modes of thought have little appeal; they sneer at all the hype about hypertext and return to their studies or their library carrels to hold in their hands the objects they revere. Such scholars are not simply going to retire or disappear, and we need them, if a market for electronic editions is to develop. They can, with only slight difficulty, navigate a complex scholarly book like my Cornell volume, because they understand the organizational principles of such objects, principles that have gradually developed over a half millennium of print-based scholarly editing. But turn them loose in an electronic environment, and they tend to get lost: the conventions of organizing electronic books have yet to be established; there are few of the organizational signposts, such as page numbers or clearly marked cross-references, that they are familiar with; and the text they are investigating often seems buried in a wealth of commentary, associated texts, parallel versions of texts, images, and even film clips. Frustration sets in, they turn off the computer, they don’t go back, and as a result publishers may become increasingly reluctant to invest money in experimental electronic projects. In short, it is incumbent on those of us making electronic editions to make them as easy to use as possible for the inexperienced user, and the nonlinear, hypertext model, at least as it has been described and projected, won’t do.

My main point, then, is simple: extensive annotation can work in print, primarily because the organizational principles of the medium are firmly established and implicitly understood by most readers. Extensive annotation in the electronic medium, however, is more problematic. On the one hand, it is extremely tempting to create superannotated editions, bringing a given text together with all its sources, all its commentary, all its reviews, all its illustrations, even all its parodies and film adaptations. But until the conventions of the electronic edition are securely established, too many potential users will find these editions too difficult to navigate. In the early days of the computer era, we do not need to dazzle people with our scholarly editions; we need to give them things they can use today and find editions in some ways better or more useful than what they have in print format. To do so, we need to keep things simple and obvious. And we also need to have finished projects, not just cyberdreams of promises we are not likely to be able to keep. With a body of such editions, we can begin to

learn just what the electronic edition can do, from the perspective of someone other than a member of an inner circle of enthusiasts. We can discover and establish the most sensible means of organizing electronic editions; we can establish conventions of organization that will gradually allow us to organize them more complexly. And then we can begin to see the ways in which this new medium can radically change what we, as scholars, actually do.

NOTES

¹No account of the publisher's advertisements published in *Lyrical Ballads* (1798) can be found in the Butler-Green edition.

²A fuller account of this project can be found in Graver and Tetreault.

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